

theatre

Pulling the Strings

MUMBAI Katkatha's *About Ram* is a new media theatre presentation which uses puppets that seem to breathe and sigh with human emotion. Based on Bhavabhuti's *Uttararamacharita*, *About Ram* presents the lonely journey of Lord Ram, the king and leader, as opposed to the popular notion of him as the unchallenged king. Funded by the India Foundation for the Arts as part of their new performances initiative, it is directed by puppeteer and theatre director Anurupa Roy. Performed by not one but three puppeteers and Roy, the show is interspersed with dance and breathtaking animation by Vishal Dhar. The central character of Ram is a three-foot high puppet manipulated by puppeteers who unlike the traditional form are present on the stage. The presence of three puppeteers promises simultaneous movement of all the parts of the puppet and makes it more lively. This form is closest to the traditional Japanese form of puppetry called Bunraku, where the

puppeteers are also performers.

Ram's solitary status is shown via his heaving chest while his pain is conveyed through controlled music and deft lighting. Some significant moments in the play are the interaction between Hanuman and Ram, where a mask is used to show the change in character, with movements that are reminiscent of the tribal martial dance Chhau; the battle between Ram and Ravana, who in this interpretation could be an alter ego; and the image of a lonely Sita sitting in the Ashoka vana before the entry of Hanuman. At the end of the performance, Ram sits on his throne and the drapes around his shoulders flow onto the stage when the audience is informed that he ruled for 10,000 years, alone. All the grandeur, however, fails to disguise his sadness. *About Ram* is a must watch for the sheer brilliance of craft as well as the infusion of soul into what are otherwise considered lifeless puppets. On May 10 and 11 at Prithvi Theatre, Mumbai and May 30 and 31 at Epic Centre, Gurgaon.

by Nirmala Ravindran

IN CONTROL: The three puppeteers of *About Ram*



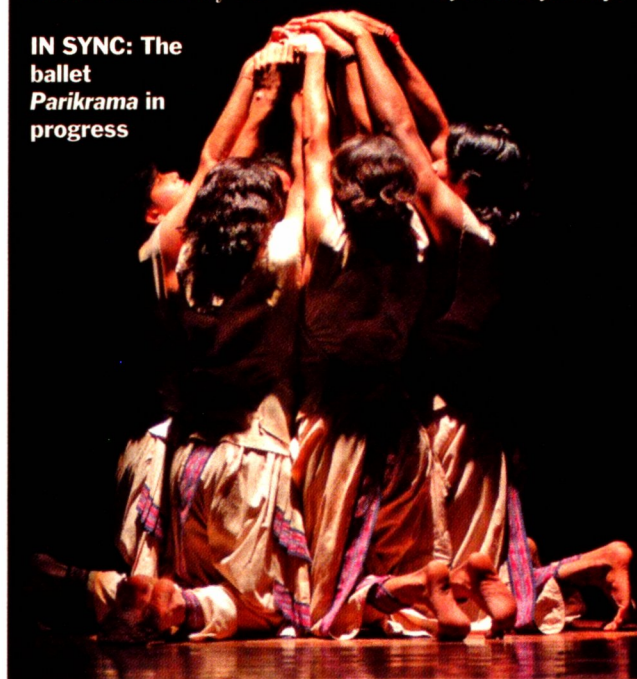
dance

Mythical Moves

DELHI Imagine a dance form that originated in the Italian Renaissance, evolved largely in France and Russia and is now being adapted to portray Indian mythology. Beginning May 9, Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra presents a festival of ballet. The choreography of these ballets is varied and is inspired by Chhau, Kathak and other folk forms. But what adds novelty to this festival is the modern interpretation of mythological characters like Karna, Shree Durga and Meera. "Meera's life seems to be an allegory for today's woman. Like Meera, who challenged the feudal order, women today need to fight the odds in this male-dominated society," says Shobha Deepak Singh, director of the ballet. The line-up: *Shree Durga* on May 9, *Karna* on May 10, *Meera* on May 10 and *Parikrama* on May 16.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

IN SYNC: The ballet *Parikrama* in progress



art

Talking Head

DELHI In the 1980s, artist E.H. Pushkin was one of the founding members of Radical Painters and Sculptors Association that stood for socially and politically conscious art. Pushkin's solo exhibition, *Somebody is Talking About Your Life*, is his first show outside Kerala. The imagery is minimal, stark and



Pushkin's work

direct. The objects depicted in the show are common, but have an emotional association of a very personal kind with Pushkin. At Gallery Espace from May 14 till June 7.